

India Unplugged

Let's hack the definitions

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Some of us don't read the newspapers, and for such folks, here's breaking news: our former telecom and IT minister Dayanidhi Maran recently said free broadband in India could happen in just two years' time. This year (2007) happens to have been declared the year of broadband (when and by whom we don't know), so this is an apt time for the announcement.

So who's going to fund this? Well, there happens to be something called the Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF), to which all telecom operators contribute 5 per cent of their revenues every year. The government plans to use what's unused in that bank of money. In addition, traffic

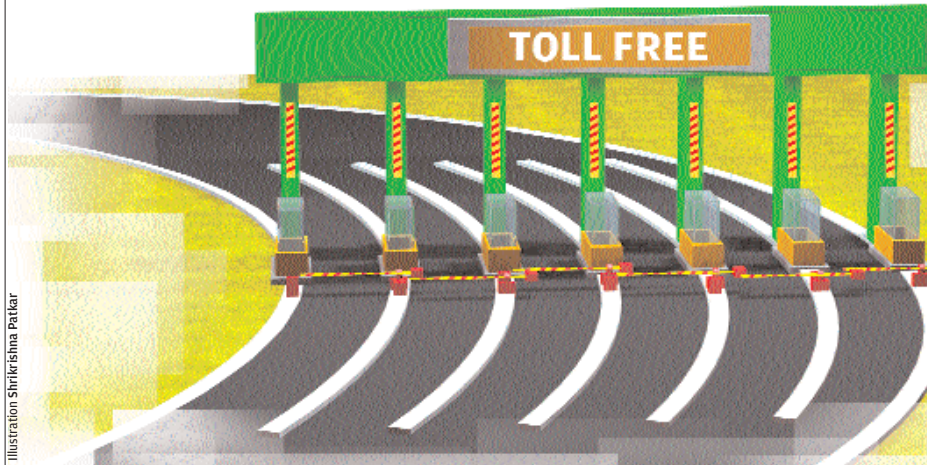


Illustration: Shrikishna Patkar

within the country will be routed within the country, courtesy the National Internet eXchange of India (www.nixi.in).

Then came the news about a week later of license fees for ISPs going up, and Internet Service Providers Association of India President, Rajesh Chharia has said that the licence fees will affect the end-user, that the cost of broadband services will increase by 6 to 24 per cent.

That, then, is the future of broadband in India: announcement will follow announcement, and soon, we'll see novel ways and means of getting around the problem. Want broadband penetration to increase? Call 56 Kbps broadband. So, soon, we'll all have broadband connections.

In lands where announcements aren't taken very seriously, and things just get done without all the fun fanfare and partying, the future lies in FTTH (Fibre To The Home), as underlined by Hartwig Tauber, president of the FTTH Council Europe. All fibre deployments will migrate towards and eventually arrive at FTTH. "It is the end-game reference technology for broadband, owing to its near unlimited capacity and non-degrading reliability..." FTTH? Believe it! Recall that when talking about VDSL (Very high-bandwidth DSL) in a past issue of *Digit*, we interviewed Jagbir Singh, then group CTO, Infotel, Bharti Tele-

Ventures Ltd. He said Fibre To The Home (FTTH) holds the most potential as the technology for broadband services. Which means we'll probably jump straight to it, bypassing ADSL2, ADSL2+, and all those other, slow technologies. (FTTH means no copper anywhere, and fibre all the way.) A fully-fibre-connected India by, oh, 2012? It's only the minor matter of an announcement.

Non-Scandinavian Europe wants Sweden-type connections. Now, in these countries, we see a strange convention: broadband definitions, instead of starting with a "K", start with "M" and "G". Something has been lost in translation: in music, the Germans use "H" for "B", for example. All those foreign-language speakers are a confused lot.

Why do we need more bandwidth than we already have? HD streaming, for one. All it needs is some reshuffling of definitions: "HD" can stand for "Hard to Define." So soon, we'll have HD content streamed over our 28.8 Kbps pipes—it'll be grainy, so you won't be able to define it.

"Economic development" is often cited as the reason for the need for broadband, like Mr Maran did regarding free broadband in India. Now, since India is a *developing* country, just add 2 and 2, and you'll realise what he means: that we're developing broadband. Soon, we'll see 14.4 Kbps connections fuelling our economic growth.

Continuing on the everything-on-the-Internet theme of another section in this issue, an interesting insight comes from Tauber: "Future bandwidth demand will be driven by more specialised, personalised content. Multi-channel TV has

offered a glimpse of this... This specialisation also drives users' aspirations to interact with, or even create, content. The natural evolution of TV-type services in the ultrahigh-speed broadband world will eventually see subscribers managing and developing their own content, with all users able to distribute high-quality video."

It's easy to see how misguided Mr Tauber is: what will happen is that home-made pornography will proliferate! Immoral Westerners corrupting our culture! No Internet scandals please, we're Indian! Keep your M and G away—we're content with our 2.2 Kbps connections!

If you think we're kidding about broadband definitions, allow us to inform you that this writer once had a conversation with customer service—when the Net connection seemed a bit iffy—at a leading Indian ISP, which calls Family Packs "up to 256 Kbps" broadband: "My download speeds are low. It doesn't cross 130 Kbps. Is that broadband, for God's sake?" "Yes." "But sometimes it comes to 50 Kbps! Is that broadband?" "Yes." "Are you saying anything is broadband?" "Sir, I wish to inform you that..." Slam.

Let's cut to the chase. Call 0.0 Kbps broadband, make an announcement, and one large, happy family we'll be of wireless broadband customers. (Just unplug the wire) ☒